

1151–55



Monks Mound, the largest mound at Cahokia, is over 100 ft (30 m) high. It has been estimated that it took 15 million baskets of earth to make it.

THE CITY OF CAHOKIA SPRANG UP AT THE CLIMAX of the Mississippian (or Cahokian) culture of the American Bottom (an area of the Mississippi river valley). Around the mid-12th century they constructed more than **100 mounds**, including one with a base that is larger than that of the Great Pyramid at Giza, along with a huge landscaped plaza that may be the **biggest earthen city square in the world**. The most remarkable feature of Cahokia is the speed with which it came into existence. Until around 1050, **Mississippians** lived in small villages and had never built on anything approaching this scale. By the 1150s the city may have covered **493 hectares (1,200 acres)** and been home to **30,000 people**. Its cultural and economic influence spread across the **Midwest**, from the present Canadian border to the Gulf Coast. Perhaps because urban living was so exceptional for the

Mississippians, Cahokia would **decline rapidly**, within around a century, with a return to low-density farming communities.

In 1152, **Conrad III** (b. 1093), king of the Romans, died and his nephew **Frederick of Swabia**, known as **Barbarossa** (see panel, below) was elected as successor. Of combined Welf and Waiblinger parentage (see 1131–35), he brought relative peace to Germany. His coronation as **emperor** in Rome was delayed because the city was in the grip of a **revolutionary commune** led by radical reformer **Arnold of Brescia** (1090–1155). Frederick allied with the papacy against Arnold and Norman Sicily, making his first expedition to Italy in 1154. The following year, in the face of Roman hostility, he was crowned by the new pope, **Adrian IV** (1100–59), but had to retreat to Germany, abandoning Adrian, who was forced to ally himself with the **Normans**.

FREDERICK BARBAROSSA (1122–90)



Energetic and ambitious, Frederick I was determined to make Germany the dominant state in Europe, and to reassert authority over all the imperial lands in Italy. Aware of the historic context of his office, he desired to restore the imperial crown to Roman-era glory, and began to style his realm the Holy Roman Empire. In Germany, he pacified rebels and expanded royal lands.

1156–60



The University of Bologna was originally a school for jurists.

WITH ORIGINS DATING BACK TO PERHAPS 1088, BOLOGNA CLAIMS to be the **oldest university** in the Western world (see 1116–20)—in the sense of an institution specifically designated as a **universitas**, as opposed to a *studium generale*, as centers for teaching had previously been known. In 1158, the emperor **Frederick I** (1122–90), on the advice of scholars who may have been **Bologna alumni**, granted the university a charter, firmly establishing the institution as an **independent center of scholarship**. Early universities tended to specialize in one field of study, and Bologna was **dedicated to law**.

In 1159, **Alexander III** (c. 1100–81) was chosen as pope, although his election was opposed by the emperor, **Frederick I**. Frederick had once again invaded Italy, this time intent on assuming his full imperial inheritance. With the aid of the **League of Pavia** (Brescia, Parma, and others), he had subdued Milan and its associated cities, but at the **Diet of Roncaglia**, in 1158, he went too far. Harking back to the Roman era, Frederick insisted that ancient law gave him the right to appoint an **imperial podestà** (local governor) to rule each city. Milan was pushed into revolt, and other cities joined them in forming a **Lombard League** under the auspices of the papacy. Alexander III would earn the title “**the Great**” for leading this anti-imperial rebellion.

1161–65



The Hassan Tower in Rabat, Morocco, is all that was built of what was intended to be an Almohad super-mosque.



The Bodhisattva Guanyin
This 12th-century Chinese statue depicts the Buddhist deity Guanyin, who protects those in danger—perhaps accounting for his popularity.

IN 1161, THE SOUTHERN SONG REPULSED AN INCURSION by the northern Jin (see 1126–30), securing their kingdom from invasion. A peace treaty of 1165 recognized an uneasy truce between the two powers.

The **Almohad** caliph **Abd al-Mu'min** died in 1163, having destroyed the **Almoravids** and extended Almohad rule from Morocco to Tunisia (the province of Ifriqiya). He made his office

hereditary, and his son **Yusuf abn Ya'qub** (1135–84) succeeded him. He would spend most of his reign battling **internal opposition**, although he was also noted for military success in **Muslim Spain** and for his patronage of the arts.

In 1164, the Zengid emir **Nur al-Din** (1118–74) defeated the Crusader princes at **Artah**.

Throughout the 1160s, Nur al-Din contested with the Crusader kingdoms, particularly as they vied for control of the **ailing**

Fatimid kingdom in Egypt, led by the vizier **Shawar**.

Amalric, who had become king of Jerusalem in 1162, was the first to occupy

Egypt, but **Zengid success** at Artah forced him to march north, leaving the way clear for Nur al-Din's general Shirkuh and his nephew **Saladin** to invade Egypt (see 1167).

Around the mid-12th century, the dense urban culture of the ancient **Pueblo peoples** at **Chaco Canyon** in North America collapsed, probably because their marginal system of agriculture had overtaxed the **fragile dryland ecology**, leaving them vulnerable to drought. Dating of timbers from the Chaco Canyon pueblos shows that the newest timbers date from around the 1160s—in other words, there was no construction after this. Other Pueblo, or **Anasazi**, sites show evidence from this period of fortification, destruction, and even cannibalism, but there is also evidence of orderly abandonment, presumably by people moving to new sites.

- c. 1150s Climax of the Cahokia mound settlement, North America
- 1151 First use of gunpowder explosives in warfare in China
- 1152 Eleanor of Aquitaine marries Henry of Anjou; their combined lands create the Angevin Empire
- 1152 Frederick I (Barbarossa) succeeds Conrad as king of the Romans
- 1153 Jin move their capital from Manchuria to Beijing
- 1154 Henry II becomes king of England
- 1155 Frederick I crowned emperor

- c. 1156 Yoruba city states are flourishing in West Africa
- 1158 Frederick I grants charter to Bologna University, Italy
- 1159 Election of Pope Alexander III, the Great; formation of Lombard League to oppose Frederick in Italy

- 1161 Battle of Zaishi; Southern Song repulse Jin invasion, China
- 1162 Thomas Becket becomes Archbishop of Canterbury
- 1163 Yusuf abn Ya'qub becomes Almohad caliph
- 1164 Battle of Artah; Nur al-Din captures Prince Bohemond III of Antioch
- 1164 Constitutions of Clarendon issued by Henry II of England to curb the power of papal authority
- c. 1165 Collapse of Chaco Canyon Pueblo culture